

It took a constant effort to consider these suggestions seriously. However, responding dogmatically is unhelpful. Compromising by automatically splitting the difference doesn't work either.

I've found that every suggestion should be subjected to the same rigorous scientific inquiry that led to the creation of the Lean Startup in the first place. Can we use the theory to predict the results of the proposed change? Can we incubate the change in a small team and see what happens? Can we measure its impact? Whenever they could be implemented, these approaches have allowed me to increase my own learning and, more important, the productivity of the companies I have worked with. Many of the Lean Startup techniques that we pioneered at IMVU are not my original contributions. Rather, they were conceived, incubated, and executed by employees who brought their own creativity and talent to the task.

Above all, I faced this common question: How do we know that "your way" of building a company will work? What other companies are using it? Who has become rich and famous as a result? These questions are sensible. The titans of our industry are all working in a slower, more linear way. Why are we doing something different?

It is these questions that require the use of theory to answer. Those who look to adopt the Lean Startup as a defined set of steps or tactics will not succeed. I had to learn this the hard way. In a startup situation, things constantly go wrong. When that happens, we face the age-old dilemma summarized by Deming: How do we know that the problem is due to a special cause versus a systemic cause? If we're in the middle of adopting a new way of working, the temptation will always be to blame the new system for the problems that arise. Sometimes that tendency is correct, sometimes not. Learning to tell the difference requires theory. You have to be able to predict the outcome of the changes you make to tell if the problems that result are really problems.

For example, changing the definition of productivity for a team from functional excellence—excellence in marketing, sales, or product development—to validated learning will cause problems.